

Structured Query Language

02 August 2026 08:45

There are many relational database management system(RDBMS) such as MySQL, Microsoft SQL Server, PostgreSQL, Oracle, etc. that allow us to create a database consisting of relations. These RDBMS also allow us to store, retrieve and manipulate data on that database through queries.

Structured Query Language (SQL)

One has to write application programs to access data in case of a file system. However, for database management system, there are a special kind of languages called Query language that can be used to access and manipulate data from the database. The Structured Query Language (SQL) is the most popular query language used by major relational database management systems such as MySQL, Oracle, SQL Server, etc.

SQL is easy to learn as the statements comprise of descriptive English words and are not case sensitive. We can create and interact with a database using SQL easily. Benefit of using SQL is that we do not have to specify how to get the data from the database. Rather, we simply specify what is to be retrieved and SQL does the rest. Although called a query language, SQL can do much more beside querying. SQL provides statements for defining the structure of the data, manipulating data in the database, declaring constraints, and retrieving data from the database in various ways depending on our requirements.

Data types and constraints in MySQL

We know that data. Consist of one or more relations and each relation (table) is made up of attributes (column) Each attribute has a data type. We can also specify constraints for each attribute of a relation.

Data type of attribute

Data type of an attribute indicates the type of data value that an attribute can have. It also decides the operations that can be performed on the data. Of that attribute. For example, arithmetic operations can be performed on numeric data, but not on character data. Commonly used data types in MySQL are numeric types, date and time types, and string types.

Commonly used data types in MySQL

Data type	Description
CHAR(n)	Specifies character type data of length N, where N could be any value from zero to 255. CHAR is of fixed length means declaring CHAR(10) implies to reserve spaces for ten characters. If data does not have 10 characters (Example city has four characters) MySQL fills the remaining six characters with spaces padded on the right.
VARCHAR(n)	The specifies character type data of length where N could be any value from zero to 65,535. But unlike CHAR VARCHAR (N) is a variable length data type. That is declaring VARCHAR (30) means a

	maximum of 30 characters can be stored, but the actual allocated bytes will depend on the length of entering string. So 'city' in VARCHAR(30) will occupy space needed to store four characters only.
INT	Int specifies an integer value. Each int value occupies four bytes of storage. The range of unassigned values allowed in a four byte integer type are 0 to 4294967295. For values larger than that we have to use BIGINT which occupies eight bytes.
FLOAT	Holds number with decimal points. Each float value occupies four bytes.
DATE	The DATE type is used for dates in 'YYYY-MM-DD' Format. YYYY is the 4-digit year, MM is the 2 digit month and DD is the 2-digit day. The supporting range is '1000-01-01' to '9999-12-31'.

Constraints: Constraints are the certain types of restrictions on the data values that an attribute can have. They are used to ensure correctness of data. However, it is not mandatory to define constraints for each attribute of a table.

Commonly used constraints

Constraints	Description
NOT NULL	Ensures that the column cannot have null values, where NULL means. Missing unknown or not applicable values.
UNIQUE	Ensures that all the values in a column are distinct or unique.
DEFAULT	A default value specified for the column if no value is provided.
PRIMARY KEY	The column which can uniquely identify each row or record in a table.
FOREIGN KEY	The column which refers to a value of an attribute defined as a primary key in another table.

SQL for data definition

In order to be able to store data, we need to first define the relation schema. Defining a schema includes. Creating a relation and giving name to relation, identifying the attributes in a relation, deciding upon the data type for each attribute and also specify the constraints as per requirements. Sometimes we may require to make changes to the relation schema also. SQL allows us to write statements for defining, modifying and deleting relation schemas. These are part of Data Definition Language (DDL).

We have already learned that the data are stored in relations or tables in a database. Hence we can say that database is a collection of tables. The CREATE statement is used to create a database and its table (relations) Before creating a database we should be clear about the number of tables and database will have the. Columns (attributes) in each table, along with the data type of each column and its constraints, if any.

Create Database

To create a database we use the CREATE DATABASE statement as shown in the following

syntax:

```
CREATE DATABASE databasename;
```

To create a database, calls. Student attendance we will type the following command at MySQL prompt.

A RDBMS can manage multiple databases on 1 computer. Therefore, we need to select the database that we want to use. To know the names of existing databases, we use the statement SHOW DATABASES. From the listed databases we can select the database to be used. Once the database is selected, we can proceed with creating tables or querying data.

In order to use the student attendance database, the following SQL statement is required.

```
mysql> USE student_attendance;  
Database changed
```

Initially the created database is empty. It can be checked by using the SHOW TABLES statement that lists names of all the tables within the database.

```
mysql> SHOW TABLES;  
Empty set (0.027 sec)
```

Create table

After creating a database student_attendance, we need to define relations in this database and specify attributes for each relation along with data type and constraints(if any) for each attribute. This is done using the CREATE TABLE statement.

Syntax:

```
CREATE TABLE tablename(  
    Attributename1 datatype constraint,  
    Attributename2 datatype constraint,  
    Attributename3 datatype constraint,  
    ...  
    Attributenamen datatype constraint  
);
```

Important to observe the following points with respect to CREATE TABLE statement:

- The number of columns in a table defines the degree of that relation, which is denoted by N.
- Attribute name specifies the name of the column in the table.
- Data type species. Type of data that an attribute can hold.
- Constraints indicate the restriction imposed on the value of an attribute. By default, each attribute can take null values except for the primary key.

```
mysql> create table student( rollnum int, name varchar(30), dob date, guid char(12), primary key(rollnum) );  
Query OK, 0 rows affected (0.049 sec)  
  
mysql> show tables  
-> ;  
+-----+  
| Tables_in_student_attendance |  
+-----+  
| student                       |  
+-----+  
1 row in set (0.010 sec)
```

← use this command to see the existence of the table in the database.

We can view the structure of already created table using.

```
+-----+
| student |
+-----+
1 row in set (0.010 sec)

mysql> describe student;
+-----+
| Field | Type | Null | Key | Default | Extra |
+-----+
| rollnum | int | NO | PRI | NULL | |
| name | varchar(30) | YES | | NULL | |
| dob | date | YES | | NULL | |
| guid | char(12) | YES | | NULL | |
+-----+
4 rows in set (0.022 sec)
```

We can view the structure of already created table using DESCRIBE statement.